



Mobile musket

This flintlock musket from 1741 is the precursor of the rifle. More portable and accurate than earlier guns, it also had a fixed ring bayonet.

“The masterpiece of a successful general is to **starve his enemy.**”

FREDERICK II OF PRUSSIA, ATTRIBUTED

only 19 years earlier (see pp.262–63) contained almost nothing about non-European matters in its collection of treaties, which demonstrates how rapidly Europe’s overseas possessions had grown in importance.

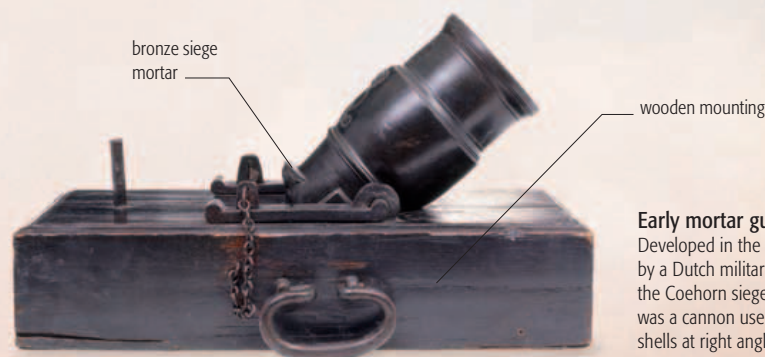
On a war footing

One effect of frequent wars was that large and properly equipped armies and navies had to be maintained, and this required centralized and bureaucratic states to run them. Countries now developed national armed forces as they became an integral element of nation-building. The Dutch were a typical example of how a government’s administration and finances were now geared to the ability to mobilize for war and buttress the state’s power.

With Europe’s political geography much more stable at home, the “standing army” of well-drilled, better provisioned, and uniformed troops that

did not “stand down” (disband) every winter slowly became the norm. The days of the mercenary captains raising private armies for a fee were numbered. Militarism, the central aim of which was the financing and organizing of professional armies, was increasing so that by the 1690s, France, fighting a European coalition, could mobilize upward of 340,000 troops. Even at peace the French standing army numbered 150,000 troops, compared

with 55,000 in the 1660s. Prussian mobilization in the 18th century could raise an army of 185,000 from a population of only five million. Warfare came of age with key developments in the study of strategy, siege tactics, topography, and ballistics. Weapons and ammunition were also refined, and logistics became more of a science as soldiers were now part of the state’s permanent expenses. The emphasis switched to defense from aggression.



Early mortar gun

Developed in the 17th century by a Dutch military engineer, the Coehorn siege mortar gun was a cannon used to fire shells at right angles.

Europe’s military power grew in sophistication and scope, soon to be “exported” to the rest of the world.

NAPOLEONIC WARFARE

Warfare went through another modernization during the Napoleonic period **306–07** >> with the **formation of military training schools**. During the Napoleonic Wars (1799–1815), Napoleon Bonaparte introduced the method of deploying massed artillery at a specific point in a battle, thereby giving him sensational victories.

EUROPE’S FIRST PROFESSIONAL ARMY

Russia had the first European army in which **all the men wore uniforms** and private soldiers were decorated for bravery—almost unknown in the rest of Europe. Troops were directly recruited and financed by the state—**peasant conscripts served for life** until 1793.

THE SEVEN YEARS WAR

The Seven Years War **296–97** >> involved both Europe and colonies in the Americas for the first time. It is considered to be the first truly global conflict in history.

